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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: No Date Given

Coverage Date: 1910 AD - 1963 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): DRESS

Iron seems to have been very scarce and hard tools were usually made from bastard ebony. Salt was obtained from water collected from pools.

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POLITICAL SYSTEM (Young and Fosbrooke, pp. 41–2, 78–118)

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Prior to colonial rule, each local matrilineage formed the core of an independent political unit (cf, clans and lineages). Occasionally, however, an outstanding rainmaker or lineage leader exerted influence beyond his kin group (sometimes even beyond the Luguru) and obtained tribute (*chamilandega* or *sengwa*) from other groups. Such a trend was not, apparently, completely institutionalized. There was no formal unification of this highly acephalous society until colonial rule. Whatever local cohesion existed prior to this was based upon marital alliances and cognatic ties between lineages and upon evanescent ritual claims of individual leaders.

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The Germans introduced resident *akidas* over the Luguru and in the 1920's the British established a Native Authority, first under two sultans chosen by the British from among a number of prominent lineage heads. In 1936, these were consolidated under one sultan, later aided by an assistant sultan, with subchiefs and headmen with a common Native Authority and common system of courts and administrative clerks. This has been completely reorganised since national Independence.

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JOKING RELATIONSHIPS (McVicar, 1935; Christensen; Mzuanda, pp. 150–2; Young and Fosbrooke, pp. 44–5)

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Luguru joking relations (*utani* or *ugonga*) have attracted more attention in publication than perhaps any other aspect of their society except land tenure and land usage. Joking relations exist between Luguru and certain tribal groups such as the Mbunga, Pogoro, Zaramo and Nyamwezi; they also exist between some Luguru clans which provide certain ritual and burial services for one another; and they exist between classificatory cross-cousins. All such persons may be called *watani* and, to varying degrees, may be joked with obscenely, have their property taken, and be generally subjected to horseplay. Despite the amount written on this topic, no proper analytical account of it exists.

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CLAN AND LINEAGE (There is no full clan list available: various incomplete, overlapping lists may be found in Young and Fosbrooke, p. 186; Scheerder and Tastevin, pp. 255–60, with associated names; Wallis, who lists subordinate lineages; Mzuanda, pp. 17–86, who provides many clan histories and much

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detailed information; Morogoro District Book; for a discussion of Luguru clans and lineages, cf also: Young and Fosbrooke, pp. 43–77; Beidelman (1960); McVicar (1935); Cory (1956)

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Clans

The Luguru are divided into over fifty exogamous matrilineal clans (*lukolo*, *lukero*, *kungugo*). The clans have histories and traditions which associate them with certain general areas, but they are not land-owning units. Nor are they associated with any totemic or dietary prohibitions. Some of these clans are linked with one another and may not intermarry. Some are also linked as special joking and ritual partners and it is maintained by some that such clans should not intermarry. Luguru are also said to have certain patrilineal groups whose only function seems to be to transmit food prohibitions.

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Each matri-clan is divided into a number of matrilineages and each of these is associated with a particular area of land over which the lineage holds corporate rights (Young and Fosbrooke, p. 43). In the past the basic political unit amongst Luguru was the matrilineage; not only did it approximate to settlement groups (cf. below) but membership in it determined political allegiance, as in the settlement and in avenging feuds. Lineages are ranked in terms of seniority: *tombo dukuru* (large breast), *tombo dukati* (middle breast), and *tombo dudogo* (small breast). McVicar (1935, p. 66) terms these units *mlango*. Details on these are lacking, but they seem to be ranked in terms of certain rights to perform ancestral propitiation ceremonies.

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